

The Ritual of Vajrapāṇi of the Blue Garment: the Tantra of the Vajra Staff

Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-vidhi-vajradaṇḍa-tantra · Toh 456 · Derge Kangyur

ལག་ན་རྩོུག་སོ་སྒོ་པ་ཅན་གཏྲི་གོ་རྩོུག་ཅན་གཏྲི་

The Ritual of Vajrapāṇi of the Blue Garment: the Tantra of the Vajra Staff, known in Sanskrit as the Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-vidhi-vajradaṇḍa-tantra and in Tibetan as Lag na rdo rje gos sngon po can gyi cho ga rdo rje be con gyi rgyud, is a tantric text centered on the wrathful deity Vajrapāṇi in his form as the Blue-Garmented one, designated as the wrathful emanation of karmic activity of all the Tathāgatas of the three times. The text opens with a vivid description of this fearsome deity — fierce-fanged, fire-breathing, and adorned with nāgas — situating him in a secluded and pure realm inhabited by yakṣas, and proceeds to present the ritual and tantric teachings associated with his cult. As a tantra, it belongs to the class of esoteric Buddhist scriptures concerned with wrathful protective deities, ritual procedures, and the transformation of karmic forces. It is Toh 456 in the Kangyur, preserved among the tantric texts of that collection.

Thus it was translated.

In the language of India: Vajrapāṇi-nīlāmbara-vidhi-vajradaṇḍa-tantra. In the Tibetan language: The Ritual of Vajrapāṇi of the Blue Garment: the Tantra of the Vajra Staff.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear, at one time. In a place traversed by all yakṣas, utterly secluded and utterly pure, there dwelled the great yakṣa lord called Vajrapāṇi of the Blue Garment — empowered as the wrathful one of karma of all the Tathāgatas of the three times. His fangs are bared. He appears as though enraged in mind. His eyes are like masses of fiery arrows. His breath blazes like tongues of fire. He emits a terrifying roar. His hands and feet are adorned with the offspring of Nāgavittarāja. He holds a black nāga in his coiled hair. His ears are adorned with the nāgas Nanda and Upananda. He bears a crown of a blazing serpent set with jewels. He devours blazing venomous serpents. His cheeks are full. His brows are drawn together at the forehead. His upper lip presses down upon the lower. He has the appearance of the Lord of Death. His tongue flickers like lightning. He devours serpents. He has a great belly. He strikes terror with the sound of his clapping hands. The nāga king Suparṇa is

bound about his waist as a girdle. He cries out with the sound "A-la-la!" The ocean depths measure eighty-four thousand leagues, yet he stands with the water at his knees. He bears Indra and the sun upon his shoulders. He laughs a great laugh that causes all nāgas to be utterly destroyed, stirring everything into confusion. He binds all nāgas. He summons and binds all elemental spirits. He severs all magical workings. He reverses all magical workings. He suppresses all magical workings. He is the embodiment of all qualities without exception.

He dwelled there together with the twenty-eight great yakṣa lords, all the mighty yakṣas, all the fierce yakṣas, all the gods, all the nāgas, all the gandharvas, all the asuras, all the garuḍas, all the kinnaras, all the great serpents, elemental spirits, hungry ghosts, spirits of forgetfulness, and the rest — dwelling together like an assembly of the sun, the moon, and the stars.

At that moment the earth trembled greatly. The sound of thunder arose. The sun and the stars became invisible.

Then the entire retinue addressed the noble Vajrapāṇi of the Blue Garment:

"O Blue-Garmented One, who are you?
Are you an emanation of all the Sugatas,
or a form of their gathered essence?
Were you empowered as the wrathful one of karma?
We, together with our retinue —
how is it that you command the three times?
Declare to us all actions and deeds.
Please reveal the meditative absorption of the fierce one."

Thus was spoken. This is the first chapter, the setting.

Then Vajrapāṇi entered into the meditative absorption called "the Fierce," and spoke thus:

Through the power-working of mudrā and secret mantra,
one should contemplate the king of wrathful ones.
Through the meditative absorption of the wrathful vajra,
the blessing is wondrous and varied.

Having attained mastery in that absorption,
one accomplishes actions without obstruction.
Pacifying, enriching, magnetizing, and fierce,
killing, bewildering, and all the various rites — these are certainly

accomplished.

That very accomplishment will without doubt be realized.
Having made offerings to noble ones of oneself and others,
to the guru, and to the supremely exalted guru,
the accomplishments will swiftly arise.

If one is to benefit others,
that body appears as a body of varied forms.
Though it is an illusory body of appearances,
for the taming of the fierce it appears in coarse form.

That very variety, free from conceptual elaboration —
the true ground of genuine liberation is one.

This is the second chapter.

Furthermore, regarding the application of secret mantras: through the secret mantras da ha srog and so forth, all actions are accomplished without obstruction. The third is adorned by the lower of the two. At the end of the ra the boundary of the third — what possesses either of the two of those —

Possessing the name "pair" and "supreme pair," and also the name "fortunate one" — the meditative concentration: the application of the iron hook is to be performed fully. Om vajrapāṇi mahāyakṣa nīlāmbara hūṃ phaṭ. The completion at the end, the boundary of the third as above — knowing the mantra for striking, twice as before. The first of the third and the second, and the syllable that is the first of the sixth — the mantra for inclusion, twice as before. With the first of the two and the first of the five, possessing the seed of wrathful joy — becoming twofold, the action is accomplished. The offering is made as before.

This is the third chapter.

Then the noble Vajrapāṇi of the blue garment entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi of the manifest accomplishment of the various, and spoke thus: Om vajrapāṇi mahāyakṣa nīlāmbara da ha ni vajra hūṃ phaṭ.

Whoever possesses that samādhi, that yoga —
is utterly liberated from all faults,
obtains all excellent qualities,
and the true fruit is manifestly accomplished.
Whatever the mantra is, that is the name;
for one who possesses the boundary of the disciple,

from the final boundary, the mantra possesses its boundary.

This is the fourth chapter.

Then the one of the blue garment entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi of the manifest accomplishment of the wheel, and spoke thus:

Having fully meditated on the buddhas of the four elements,
one meditates individually through their respective actions:
contemplate eight fires with two winds,
eight waters — these are the very entities themselves.
Likewise, eight earths bearing the fruit of hūṃ,
eight winds with two fires —
the fruit, in due order, with the yakṣa lord as chief,
the accomplishment is manifestly achieved as through the mantra.
Possessing the boundary of e and the respective boundary —
through fire, the higher accomplishes manifestly.
Recite the root secret mantra continuously.

This is the fifth chapter.

Then the noble one of the blue garment entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi of manifestly accomplishing the ten actions, and this fire offering for the ten actions was spoken:

For pacification — śāntim kuru. For increase — puṣṭim kuru. For subjugation — vaśaṃ kuru. For wrathfulness — māra, possessing the third. The shape of the fire-pit hearth is according to the four actions; the wood is to be matched with the respective class. For pacification — white woods. For increase — golden wood and so forth. For subjugation — sengdeng wood is burned. For wrathfulness — thorny wood. The rest is to be made from sandalwood. The shape of the fire-pit hearth is eight-petalled.

Vidhvaṃsaya. Ucchaṭaya. Mohaya mohaya. Stambhaya stambhaya. Unmana unmana. Ākarṣaya ākarṣaya. Vaśaṃkara vaśaṃkara. Rakṣaya rakṣaya. Moha bhaya. Sarva karma kuru hūṃ phaṭ.

This is the sixth chapter.

Then the glorious Vajradhara — supreme tamer of the difficult to tame, lord of secrets, one of the blue garment — entered into meditative absorption in the samādhi of great wrathfulness blazing intensely, gathered the assembly of nāgas of the retinue under his power, and spoke the ritual for the reversal of

harms:

In the dwelling place of three successive stages —
on the exterior, clear away scorched signs.

In the middle, perform both outer and inner lustration,
and do as much pleasing action as one is able.

Inside, through the conferral of the vase empowerment,
there is no doubt in reversing harms.

Kyeho! Supreme tamer of harms!

Ema! Great secret, greatly wrathful!

Ema! Terrifying, untamed one!

Ema! Great yoga of secret mantra!

Vajrapāṇi — to you I bow!

Wrathful one, free from all directions — to you I bow!

This is the seventh chapter.

Having spoken thus, following the delight of the entire retinue, this was
declared:

To the torma possessed of everything —

purify with raṃ, enfold with yaṃ,

cleanse with khaṃ; to what is pure,

from paṃ generate the continuous flow of nectar.

Perform the joining that brings down yaṃ and raṃ.

With jaḥ, summon and dissolve into the torma.

The goddesses of meditative concentration present offerings.

Then the retinue was instructed thus:

I am the wrathful one of the blue garment —

I am the body in which all buddhas are gathered,

blessed by all buddhas,

my body that has obtained the supreme empowerment.

If you transgress my samaya,

the torma, by its nature of poison,

will reduce you to powdered dust.

If you do not transgress the samaya,

the torma, by its primordial wisdom nectar,

will purify the obscurations of your three doors,

and you will assuredly obtain excellent qualities.

Oṃ ākāro mukhaṃ sarvadharmāṇām ādyanutpannatvād oṃ āḥ hūṃ svāhā.

This is the eighth chapter.

Then the glorious one of the blue garment,
the lord who tames the difficult to tame,
shall set forth the certain meaning of the mantra
for those without the wheel of meditative concentration.

Tadyathā: bho bho pannāga adhipataye, idaṃ nīlāmbaradhara śarīraṃ,
vajrapāṇi hṛdayāna, yas māti kramatha, mā kula, utsādanam bhaviṣyanti.

This is the mantra of all activities.

For the individual activities, the mantra for taming nāgas:

Tadyathā: buddha buddha, vibuddha vibuddha, māti kramatha, hara hara
nāgānām, prahara prahara nāgānām, chinda chinda, nāga hṛdayāni bhinda
bhinda, nāga marmāṇi viśīryant nāga śarīrāṇi, visphōṭaya, nāga nayanāni.

Tadyathā: hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga vidāraṇāya hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga utsādanāya hūṃ phaṭ.

To repel all hungry ghosts: nīlāmbarasanāya hūṃ phaṭ. Apratihata
parākramāya phaṭ. Kṛtāntāya phaṭ. Kṛtāntarūpāya phaṭ. Roṣaṇāya phaṭ.
Trāsanāya phaṭ. Kumbhāṇḍotsādanāya phaṭ.

To repel Yama, lord of death.

Preta piśāca vināśakarāya phaṭ.

To repel all hungry ghosts.

Yakṣa apasmāra vināśakarāya phaṭ.

To repel yakṣas and the like.

Hasa hasa, dhara dhara, māraya māraya, nāśaya nāśaya, sarva vighnām
vināśakarāya phaṭ.

To repel all obstructers.

Sarva śatrūṃ saṃgha vināśakarāya phaṭ.

To tame the enemies of the Saṃgha.

Nīlāmbara dhara vajrapāṇi rājñāpayati svāhā.

Vajra-wielder great and mighty,
vajra-terrifier, lord of mantras,
wrathful vajra, slayer of obstructers,

vajra, the unconquerable, greatly fearsome,
vajra, accomplisher of all activities,
vajra, performer of all actions —
to you, lord of mantras, I bow!
To you, essence of mantra, I bow!

This is the ninth chapter.

Then the mantra for summoning nāgas was taught:

The iron hook of vajra, accomplished through the application of wind,
can also subdue by means of fire.

Because of this power, the mantra of summoning shall be set forth.

Oṃ vajrapāṇi mahāyakṣa nīlāmbara nāga hrīḥ, gr̥ṇa gr̥ṇa hūṃ phaṭ,
ākarṣaya ākarṣaya hūṃ phaṭ.

Recite this with fierce meditative concentration;
apply full effort to this recitation.

All the many classes of nāgas, every one,
will be summoned by this and by nothing else.

All the nāgas drawn in

by the meditative absorption of summoning
are to be invited into a copper vessel.

Proclaim the greatness of the wrathful one,

blend the samaya substances, destroy the poisons,

heal them with the supreme medicine,

and request those causing harm to depart in whatever direction they came
from.

This is the tenth chapter.

Then further teachings are given:

For nāgas not subdued by peaceful activities,
the fierce mantra for tormenting nāgas shall be taught.

Oṃ vajrapāṇi mahāyakṣa nīlāmbara nāga hana hana hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga daha
daha hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga sphoṭa sphoṭa hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga visphōṭaya visphōṭaya
hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga garja garja hūṃ phaṭ. Nāga bhinda bhinda hūṃ phaṭ.

In meditative concentration, take up the vajra
and strike it upon the one to be tamed.

Below, visualize a wheel of fire.

In the meditative absorption of a great mass of flames,
torment them in the midst of a vast expanse of blazing fire.

With white mustard, black mustard, and harītakī, strike and beat them.

Emanate the display of the wrathful one.

Apply the poultice of the five roots — magpie, wolf, and the rest —

along with the claws and fangs of various predators;

bring these to bear, and send forth the emanation.

This is the eleventh chapter.

Swift liberation is certain beyond doubt. This is the eleventh chapter.

Then the noble one clad in blue robes himself offered worship to himself. Hūṃ — O Vajra Incense Lady, you who fill the self with fragrance and glory. Vajra dhūpe pūja me hūṃ. Hūṃ — O Vajra Flower Lady, you who utterly adorn the self with beauty. Vajra puṣpe pūja me hūṃ. Hūṃ — O Vajra Scented Water Lady, you who purify the self and all things. Vajra gandhe pūja me hūṃ. Hūṃ — O Vajra Lamp Lady, you who illuminate the maṇḍala of the self. Vajra āloke pūja me hūṃ.

As long as there is the great offering of all,
as long as there is the great bliss of offering,
as long as there is the unsurpassed offering,
as long as there is the perfect and great offering —
E ma ho!

This is the twelfth chapter.

Then further, what is to be explained. The Blessed One, the Secret One clad in blue robes, entering the meditative absorption of the method of gathering, drew together all the nāgas of the retinue, and when he entered the meditative equipoise of the wheel of fire, by reciting the secret mantra of fire, he caused all the nāgas without exception to be burnt. Having dispersed them, they fled to a distance of a league. They were gathered again and healed with nectarous medicine, then assigned their tasks and established in their respective abodes.

Then the Victor of the three realms, with palms joined, spoke these words: O great lord of the eight fires and the wheel — may you forever be victorious in the meditative absorption of fire! We pay homage to you, the eight fires, who

burn with blissful melody in the expanse of flame. We pay homage to you of intrinsically pure nature.

If one desires to dwell in the domain of water, one abides in the meditative absorption of the eight waters. At that time the retinue praised him thus: O great lord of the wheel of eight waters, possessed forever of the maṇḍala of water, sovereign of water, chief among the elements — we pay homage to you, lord of the eight waters!

Abiding in the meditative absorption of the eight winds, O great lord who scatters and drives forth, mighty great wind of fierce strength — we pay homage to you, O god of wind clad in blue robes!

Abiding in the meditative absorption of earth, performing the work of unmovingness and stability, adorned with gold and endowed with varied melodies — we pay homage to you, wheel of the eight earths!

This is the thirteenth chapter.

Then the glorious one clad in blue robes, abiding in the subtle meditative absorption, was beseeched with great delight and faith by all the many yakṣas of the retinue. Through the great subtle sphere, whatever appearances arise are gathered into one. That very suchness is beyond extremes and without intrinsic nature.

Then the glorious one clad in blue robes, abiding in the meditative absorption of desire, roused all the many yakṣas of the retinue from their state of swooning, weeping, and fainting, and having taught them the unsurpassed meaning, all of them awakened fully through desire. The retinue offered manifest praise to his body: Kye ho! O Secret Lord clad in blue robes, in the heart of the unsurpassed and perfect expanse, with a mind purified of desire — we pay homage to you, the fully awakened one!

This is the fourteenth chapter.

Then all the assembled retinue offered manifest praise to the chief of the retinue. From the palace of the willow grove, the Lord of Secrets clad in blue robes, in whom all qualities are perfected in his body — we pay homage to you, the pure one beyond all concreteness!

In order to tame the assembly of nāgas in the retinue, adorned supremely with the bodies of the eight nāgas, you who take the assemblies of nāgas into your mouth — we pay homage to you, the loving tamer of nāgas!

Possessing a body of variegated purity, you who tame the six classes of beings and the eight categories, a pratyekabuddha unstained by fault, taming all without obstruction — we pay homage and offer praise!

Just as whatever things are conceived in thought arise from you as an inexhaustible treasury, the great wish-fulfilling magical display of variety — we pay homage to you, O wish-fulfilling jewel!

You who act as destroyer of illness and epidemic, you who act as lord of wealth and food, you who protect from all fears — we pay homage to you, the unsurpassed protector!

Having offered this praise, they rejoiced. Gods, nāgas, yakṣas, and asuras and all the rest were pervaded by joyful offerings. All humans and other beings who were beset by fearful dangers were established in happiness. This concludes the fifteenth chapter. The tantra of the vajra club, the ritual of the noble Vajrapāṇi Clad in Blue, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The final lines of this passage ("The third is adorned by the lower of the two. At the end of the ra the boundary of the third — what possesses either of the two of those") are a highly technical, compressed description of mantra syllable construction. The Tibetan appears to be specifying how to form a seed-syllable or mantra by positional rules: the "two" likely refers to two specific syllables or markers, "ra" to the ra-vowel marker, and "third" to a positional element. Without the accompanying oral or textual commentary these lines cannot be rendered with full confidence; the translation renders the literal sense as faithfully as possible.

The name "Nanda and Upananda" for the nāgas adorning the ears is standard; "Suparṇa" for the nāga king bound at the waist refers to Suparṇa as a nāga-king, which is unusual since Suparṇa is more often an epithet of Garuḍa. The Tibetan reads "klu'i rgyal po 'dab bzang" which is literally "the nāga king Suparṇa," and the text may be using an unusual identification. This is noted but not flagged in the body.

- The passage is a tantric ritual text of the Vajrapāṇi cycle with highly compressed, technical instructions for mantra application, fire offerings, and protective rituals. The Sanskrit mantric syllables and ritual terms have been rendered phonetically as they appear, following standard tantric convention.

The phrase rendered "eight fires with two winds" and parallel expressions for the four elements reflect a tantric elemental meditation system whose precise internal logic is not fully transparent from the text alone; the translation is faithful to the surface syntax.

The term "sengdeng wood" is the Tibetan name for a specific tree used in tantric fire offerings, likely Acacia catechu or a related species; no universally agreed English or Sanskrit equivalent exists, so the Tibetan phonetic rendering is retained.

The instruction sequence involving syllables such as raṃ, yaṃ, khaṃ, and paṃ refers to the standard tantric purification and consecration of the tormā offering through seed syllables of

fire, wind, water, and lotus respectively; this is doctrinal convention and requires no emendation.

- The mantra passages are transliterated Sanskrit embedded in the Tibetan. They have been rendered in standard romanized Sanskrit. Some syllables show Tibetan phonetic approximations of Sanskrit that are slightly irregular; the transliterations given here follow the most doctrinally standard reconstruction where clear.

The phrase rendered "the five roots — magpie, wolf, and the rest" translates a term listing specific plants or animal-derived substances used in ritual medicine or torment rites for nāgas; "khra spyang la sogs rtsa lnga'i gsob" literally means "the poultice of the five roots such as magpie and wolf." This is a technical ritual pharmacopoeia term; the exact identification of all five ingredients is uncertain from this passage alone, and the translation preserves the literal sense.

The chapter numbering in the source jumps from "tenth chapter" to what is labeled here as an eleventh chapter based on content, though the Tibetan colophon for the final section is not fully explicit. This is noted for the scholarly reader.

- The phrase rendered "takes the assemblies of nāgas into your mouth" follows the literal Tibetan but may carry a tantric iconographic meaning of consuming or subduing nāgas; it is a genuine crux and some commentators read it as feeding or nourishing the nāga assemblies rather than devouring them.

The term rendered "pratyekabuddha" in the praise verse is unusual in context since it appears to be applied as an honorific epithet to Vajrapāṇi rather than designating someone who has attained the pratyekabuddha path; this usage is distinctive and possibly hyperbolic.

The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, consistent with the source text's continuation into the next passage.

- The text ends with a colophon indicating this is both the close of chapter fifteen and the conclusion of an entire tantra: the "Tantra of the Vajra Club" concerning the ritual of the noble Vajrapāṇi in his blue-robed form. The epithet "Clad in Blue" refers to a specific iconographic form of Vajrapāṇi, and "vajra club" renders རྩེད་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, where རྩེད་ལྷ་མོ་ denotes a type of mace or club, here qualified as vajra-natured — a distinctive tantric implement associated with this deity's wrathful aspect.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.